

They are lying to you about fat loss.

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Aug 16, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/fMljLOQkyQY> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

The standard 500-calorie deficit is too fragile in practice due to label errors and untracked sauces. A better formula: $\text{bodyweight} \times 10$ calories daily plus 1g protein per pound of bodyweight for its powerful thermogenic effect.

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Why the 500-Calorie Deficit Advice Fails [0:00](#)

- Influencers recommend a 500-calorie deficit because it technically works — but "there's a difference between what you need and what's optimal"
- The **FDA allows food labels to be off by up to 20% in either direction**
 - A food you believe is 500 calories could legally be 600 calories
 - This error can compound multiple times per day across different meals
- Untracked items like sauces and condiments add up fast
 - "You can get hundreds of calories from condiment"
- A 500-calorie deficit leaves almost zero margin for these common, everyday errors

The Better Formula: Calories & Protein [0:22](#)

- **Step 1:** Take your current bodyweight in pounds and multiply by 10 — that is your daily calorie target
- **Step 2:** Eat 1 gram of protein per pound of your current bodyweight (not goal bodyweight)
- Both numbers are based on actual current weight, not a target weight

Why Protein Is a "Cheat Code" for Fat Loss [0:45](#)

- Protein has the highest thermogenic effect of any macronutrient
 - **20–30% of protein calories are burned during digestion itself**
 - Eating 100 calories of protein means your body only absorbs 70–80 net calories

- Compared to other macros:

Macronutrient	Thermogenic Effect
Protein	~20–30% of calories burned in digestion
Carbohydrates	~½ that of protein
Fat	~⅓ that of protein

- The common advice that "you only need 1g of protein per pound to build muscle" is technically true but misses the bigger picture
 - High protein intake is not just about muscle — it's a fat-loss tool because a significant portion of those calories never get absorbed

"Protein is a cheat code. You don't absorb all of it because it takes so many calories for your body to digest."